



WEIGHTY ISSUES:
A gym in Para village
outside Lucknow

THE FITNESS PHENOMENON

Para | UTTAR PRADESH



The six-pack power

From dodgy two-room gyms to ill-advised protein supplements, little India is muscling in on the physical revolution

■ By Subhash Mishra

Sit-ups, crunches, squats and bench press. These are the words that Vikas, a sweeper, who earns Rs 1,500 a month cleaning the streets of Para village on the outskirts of Lucknow, can utter in his sleep. "I want to look like a muscleman, a strongman," he says. When Vikas isn't working, he's working out at the Navchetana health club, the money enough for the Rs 200 monthly gym fees and imported protein shakes. Vikas is not alone in his dream of becoming a Salman Khan or Sanjay Dutt. "We have very young people who work as carpenters, painters, plumbers and even labourers as regulars here," says gym owner Babloo Pandey. "They are very particular

about their exercise schedule and never miss a single day."

Fitness is no longer a fad that belongs solely to the movers and shakers of urban India. There has been a mushrooming of gyms, akharas and physical fitness centres in small towns, the names of which probably don't even make it to the map. Barabanki, Sitapur, Unnao and Hardoi in Uttar Pradesh have seen a sudden surge in these fitness centres. Located in one or two-room quarters, the equipment used ranges from the brand new to the very old. As urban India jogs along manicured lawns and builds muscle tone in air-conditioned environs, for young men like Vikas, the local gym is their one sure shot to a testosterone boost.

Rs 2,000 CRORE IS THE TOTAL WORTH OF THE FITNESS INDUSTRY IN INDIA